

Session 1 Leader Guide: Never Read a Bible Verse

How (Not) to Read the Bible · College & Young Adults · Oct 4, 2026 · @Eric

Overview

Big idea: A verse means what its author meant in its context, so we never lift a verse out of the passage, the book, and the whole story of Scripture it belongs to.

This first session sets the foundation for the whole series. Every hard passage in Sessions 2–6 gets handled with the habits introduced tonight. If students leave with one reflex, it should be: *"What's the context?"*

By the end of the session, students should be able to:

1. Explain why reading a single verse in isolation leads to misreading.
2. Name the three circles of context: literary, historical, and the Bible's big story (canonical).
3. Use the Observe → Interpret → Apply method on a short passage.
4. Distinguish between "written *for* us" and "written *to* us."

Key passages for the workshop:

- Philippians 4:10–20 (the context of 4:13)
- Jeremiah 29:1–14 (the context of 29:11)
- Backup if time allows: Matthew 18:15–20 (the context of 18:20)

Prep checklist:

- ☐ Watch Session 1 on RightNow Media and note 2–3 moments you want to pause on
- ☐ Read Philippians 4 and Jeremiah 29 in full, twice
- ☐ Print one student handout per person, plus extras
- ☐ Bring a few physical Bibles in one translation (CSB or ESV) so everyone sees the same paragraph breaks
- ☐ Test the video and slides on the room's screen
- ☐ Have highlighters or colored pens on the tables for the observation step

Session plan (90 minutes)

The video takes about a quarter of the time; the hands-on workshop is the heart of the night.

Time	Segment	Minutes	What happens
0:00	Welcome & opener	10	Food, introductions, "Misused Verse" icebreaker, opening prayer
0:10	Video: Session 1	22	Students jot notes on the handout's video section
0:32	Video debrief	13	Whole group, 3–4 questions
0:45	Teach the method	8	Three circles of context + Observe → Interpret → Apply (slides)
0:53	Exegesis workshop	27	Tables of 3–4 work Philippians 4 and Jeremiah 29, then report back
1:20	Apply & pray	10	Personal application, preview of Session 2, closing prayer

If you run long: cut the Jeremiah report-back to one table and assign Jeremiah 29 as the take-home exercise on the handout.

Opener and video debrief

Icebreaker: "Misused Verse" (10 min)

Put these on the screen and ask: *"Where have you seen this verse used: a mug, a tattoo, a locker room, an Instagram caption?"*

- Philippians 4:13 ("I can do all things through him who strengthens me")
- Jeremiah 29:11 ("plans to prosper you")
- Matthew 7:1 ("Judge not")
- Matthew 18:20 ("where two or three are gathered")

Don't correct anyone yet. The point is to surface how often we meet the Bible as single, free-floating sentences. You'll come back to two of these in the workshop.

Leader note: College students often feel a little sheepish here, especially if a verse means something personal to them. Reassure them early: the goal isn't to take a verse away from them, it's to give it back with its full meaning, which is usually richer.

Video debrief questions (13 min)

1. Kimball borrows a line from apologist Greg Koukl: never read a Bible verse. What does he actually mean by that, and what doesn't he mean?

- Leader note: He means never read *only* a verse. Verse numbers were added centuries later (chapters in the 1200s, verses in the 1500s) for reference, not as units of meaning. The paragraph is usually the smallest unit of thought.

2. What's one example from the video of a verse being misread out of context? What went wrong?

- Leader note: Let students recall examples. Push them to name *which* context was ignored: the surrounding paragraph, the original audience, or the larger story.

3. Kimball says the Bible was written *for* us but not *to* us. How would you put that in your own words?

- Leader note: Every book had an original author and audience in a specific time and culture. All of Scripture is God's Word and profitable for us (2 Tim 3:16–17), but we hear it best by first hearing what it meant to *them*.

4. Why does reading the Bible as one big story matter for the hard passages we'll face later in this series?

- Leader note: Creation → Fall → Redemption → Restoration, centered on Christ (Luke 24:27). Many troubling passages describe life in a fallen world or a stage in God's unfolding plan, not God's final word or ideal. This frame will carry Sessions 2–6.

Doctrinal guardrail: Students sometimes hear "context" as "the Bible is outdated." Make clear that reading in context is how we *submit* to Scripture's authority, not how we escape it. We want what God actually said, not what we wish he said. This fits squarely with the Baptist Faith & Message's affirmation of Scripture as "truth, without any mixture of error."

Exegesis workshop

Teach the method first (8 min)

Three circles of context, from the inside out:

1. **Literary:** the sentences, paragraph, and book around the verse. What kind of writing is it (letter, prophecy, narrative, poetry)?
2. **Historical:** who wrote it, to whom, when, and what was happening to them.
3. **The big story (canonical):** where it fits in Creation → Fall → Redemption → Restoration, and how it points to Christ.

Three steps every student will use all six weeks:

1. **Observe:** What does it say? (Who, what, where, when, repeated words, connecting words like *for*, *therefore*, *but*.)
2. **Interpret:** What did it mean to the original audience? Then: what timeless truth about God and people does it teach?
3. **Apply:** How should that truth change what I believe, love, or do this week?

Stress that step 2 must come before step 3. Most misreadings jump straight from a verse to "what this means for me."

Passage 1: Philippians 4:10–20 (about 13 min)

Have tables read the whole paragraph aloud, then work the handout questions.

What students should notice (Observe):

- Paul is writing a thank-you note for a financial gift the Philippians sent (4:10, 14–18).
- He's in prison as he writes (1:7, 1:13).
- "All things" is defined by 4:12: being brought low and abounding, being hungry and being full, plenty and need.
- Key word: *content* (4:11). The "secret" Paul learned (4:12) is contentment.

Leader commentary (Interpret):

Paul isn't promising that Christ will help us win games, ace exams, or achieve any goal we set. He's saying Christ gives him strength to be content and faithful *whatever his circumstances*, including hunger and chains. That's actually a stronger promise: Christ's strength holds even when we lose, fail, or suffer.

Timeless truth: Christ's strength enables believers to be content and faithful in every circumstance, plenty or want.

Discussion prompt: *Is the verse more or less encouraging once you read it in context? Why?*

Passage 2: Jeremiah 29:1–14 (about 14 min)

What students should notice (Observe):

- This is a letter (29:1) from Jeremiah to Judeans already exiled in Babylon.
- God tells them to build houses, plant gardens, marry, and seek the welfare of Babylon (29:5–7). In other words: settle in, you're staying.
- The promise comes *after* 70 years (29:10). Most of the adults hearing it would die in exile.
- The "you" in 29:11 is plural in Hebrew: the people of Judah as a whole.
- False prophets were promising a quick return (29:8–9). God's word is the opposite.

Leader commentary (Interpret):

Jeremiah 29:11 is not a promise of individual career success or a smooth senior year. It's God's covenant pledge to restore his people after judgment, on his timeline, not theirs. It is still deeply relevant: the same faithful God holds his people's future, and his plans for them ultimately rest in Christ. But we only get there by first hearing it the way exiles in Babylon heard it.

Timeless truth: God keeps his promises to his people, even through long seasons of hardship and waiting, and calls them to live faithfully where he has placed them.

Helpful distinction for students: "Can I claim this promise?" is the wrong first question. Better: "What does this show me about God's character?" God's character doesn't change, so that's where application begins.

Report back (if time)

Ask one table per passage to share: *the verse alone said X; the verse in context says Y*. Write both on a whiteboard side by side.

Apply, field questions, and pray

Personal application (5 min)

Give students two quiet minutes with the handout's application box, then invite a few to share:

- *Which verse have you leaned on that you've never read in context? Read its chapter this week.*

These are not official materials from How (Not) to Read the Bible. They were developed solely for use by our group's members. Please do not distribute.

- *Where am I tempted to make the Bible say what I want it to say?*

Questions students are likely to ask

"So was it wrong for me to find comfort in Jeremiah 29:11?" Not wrong to find comfort in God's faithfulness. The comfort is real, it's just rooted in God's character and his covenant promises fulfilled in Christ (2 Cor 1:20), not in a guarantee about my personal plans.

"If context changes meaning, can't anyone make the Bible say anything?" The opposite. Context *limits* meaning. It's ignoring context that lets people make the Bible say anything. Meaning is anchored in what the author intended, and God, the ultimate author, intends to be understood.

"Do I need to know Greek and Hebrew to read the Bible right?" No. A good translation, a study Bible, and the habit of reading whole paragraphs will take you a long way. Tools help; humility and attention matter most.

"How do I know what's cultural and what's for all time?" Great question, and it's the subject of the next session. Hold it for next week.

Preview Session 2

Next week: *Stranger Things*. Why does Leviticus forbid tattoos and mixed fabrics, and do those laws still apply? Ask students to skim Leviticus 19 before they come.

Closing prayer

Pray Psalm 119:18 over the group, and ask God to give them humble, attentive hearts that want his Word on his terms.